

Word family: **develop / develops / developed / developing / development / developmental / developer**

Base word: develop

Forms: develops, developed, developing

Related forms: development, developmental, developer

Part of speech: verb (動詞) / related noun and adjective forms (相關名詞及形容詞)

Your sentence:

> “...it appears to tell the bigger story of how human beings **developed**, cooperated, and built societies.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **developed** means **gradually changed and became more advanced, complex, or established over time**.

In this sentence, it refers to the long-term development of human beings and human society.

繁體中文： ** **隨時間逐步發展、演變，變得更成熟、更複雜或更完善**

中文翻譯：

> “...how human beings **developed**, cooperated, and built societies.”

「.....人類如何逐步**發展 / 演變**、如何合作，以及如何建立社會。」

Here:

develop = 隨時間逐漸成長、演變或變得更成熟 / 複雜

1. **develop = grow or change gradually (發展 / 演變) — 發展 ; 演變 ; 成長**

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Meaning: To gradually become larger, stronger, more advanced, more complex, or more mature over time.

Practice 1 — Original

> “The book explains how human beings **developed** over time.”

「這本書解釋人類如何隨時間逐步**發展 / 演變**。」

Practice 2

> “The town **developed** rapidly after the railway arrived.”

「鐵路建成後，這個城鎮迅速**發展**。」

Practice 3

> “Her confidence **developed** slowly.”

「她的自信逐漸**建立 / 發展**起來。」

develop = 某人、某事物或某個系統隨時間逐步成長、演變或變得更成熟

Common:

- * develop over time
- * develop rapidly
- * develop gradually
- * develop into something

2. **develop** = create or improve something over time (開發 / 研發) — 開發 ; 研製 ; 發展

Develop can mean to create a new product, system, idea, method, technology, etc., usually through a gradual process.

Practice 4

> “The company is **developing** a new app.”

「公司正在**開發**一款新應用程式。」

Practice 5

> “Scientists **developed** a new method.”

「科學家**研發**出一種新方法。」

develop = 透過設計、測試、改良等過程，逐步創造出新的產品、技術、方法或系統

This is a major transitive sense.

3. **develop = improve a skill, ability, quality, or relationship (培養) — 培養；提升；建立**

Develop can mean to gradually strengthen an ability, quality, habit, relationship, or personal characteristic.

Practice 6

> “Reading helps children **develop** language skills.”

「閱讀有助兒童**培養**語言能力。」

Practice 7

> “They gradually **developed** a close friendship.”

「他們逐漸**建立**了親密的友誼。」

develop = 令能力、特質、習慣或關係逐步形成並變得更強

Common:

- * develop skills
- * develop confidence
- * develop a habit
- * develop a relationship
- * develop an interest

For strict counting, this is related to Meaning 1, but because it is a very common transitive pattern, it is useful to show explicitly.

4. **develop = begin to have a condition/problem/feature (出現 / 患上) — 出現；患上；形成**

Develop can mean that a disease, condition, problem, habit, symptom, or physical feature begins to appear.

Practice 8

> “He **developed** a fever overnight.”

「他一夜之間**發起燒來**。」

Practice 9

> “The machine **developed** a fault.”

「那部機器**出現了故障**。」

develop = 某種症狀、疾病、問題、特徵等開始出現

Common:

- * develop a disease
- * develop symptoms
- * develop a problem
- * develop a fault
- * develop a rash

This is a major distinct everyday sense.

5. **develop** = become clear or emerge (情況 / 故事) — 展開 ; 逐漸顯現

A situation, story, crisis, or event can **develop** as new details appear and the situation changes.

Practice 10

> “The situation **developed** quickly.”

「情況迅速**發展 / 演變**。」

Practice 11

> “We will see how the story **develops**.”

「我們會看看故事接下來如何**發展**。」

develop = 情況或事件隨時間逐步展開、變化或顯現更多細節

This is closely related to Meaning 1 and does not need a separate core count.

6. **develop** = build on land / prepare land for use (地產) — 開發土地

Develop can mean to build houses, offices, roads, etc. on land, or prepare land for commercial/residential use.

Practice 12

> “The company plans to **develop** the land.”

「公司計劃**開發**那幅土地。」

Practice 13

> “The area was heavily **developed** in the 1990s.”

「該地區在九十年代被大量**開發建設**。」

develop land = 對土地進行建設、規劃或商業 / 住宅開發

This is an established domain sense.

7. **develop** = process a photograph/film (攝影) — 沖洗 ; 顯影

Traditionally, **develop** means to chemically process photographic film or photographs so that the image becomes visible.

Practice 14

> “She had the film **developed**.”

「她把菲林拿去**沖洗 / 顯影**。」

Practice 15

> “The photographs were **developed** in a darkroom.”

「照片是在暗房裡**沖洗**出來的。」

develop = 透過化學處理令菲林上的影像顯現出來

This is still valid, though less central in the digital era.

8. **develop** = expand an idea/argument/theme (內容) — 發展 ; 闡述

In writing, speaking, music, or argumentation, **develop** can mean to expand an idea, theme, argument, or point with more detail.

Practice 16

> “You need to **develop** this argument further.”

「你需要進一步**發展 / 闡述**這個論點。」

Practice 17

> “The second chapter **develops** the main idea.”

「第二章進一步**展開**主要觀點。」

develop = 把一個想法、論點或主題進一步擴充、深入說明

This is a distinct academic/discourse use.

Related form: **development**

Development has several very important senses.

development = process of growth/change (發展)

Practice 18

> “The rapid **development** of the city changed the region.”

「城市的快速**發展**改變了整個地區。」

development = new product/idea/event (新發展 / 新進展)

Practice 19

> “There has been an important new **development**.”

「出現了一項重要的**新發展 / 新進展**。」

development = construction project (開發項目)

Practice 20

> “A new housing **development** is being built nearby.”

「附近正在興建一個新的住宅**發展項目 / 屋苑**。」

development = 發展過程；新進展；開發建設等

Related form: **developmental**

Developmental means related to growth, change, or development.

Practice 21

> “Children pass through different **developmental** stages.”

「兒童會經歷不同的**發展階段**。」

developmental = 與成長、發育或發展過程有關的

Related form: **developer**

Developer has several common meanings.

Person/company creating software

> “She works as a software **developer**.”

「她是一名軟件**開發人員**。」

Property developer

> “The land was sold to a property **developer**.”

「那幅土地賣給了一間地產**發展商**。」

developer = 開發產品、軟件或土地的人 / 公司

Important distinction: **develop** vs **grow**

grow

often emphasizes becoming bigger, older, stronger, or increasing naturally.

develop

often emphasizes gradual change toward greater complexity, maturity, capability, or completeness.

- > children grow physically
- > children develop language skills

They overlap, but **develop** often focuses more on qualitative change.

Important distinction: **develop** vs **evolve**

evolve

emphasizes gradual change over a long period, often through stages.

develop

is broader and can involve:

- * natural growth
- * improvement
- * deliberate creation
- * emergence of problems

So in your passage, **evolve** could fit historically, but **develop** is broader and more neutral.

Important distinction: **develop** vs **improve**

improve

means become better.

develop

means grow, change, form, or become more advanced.

Something can develop without necessarily becoming better.

For example:

- > “The situation developed into a crisis.”

That is development, but not improvement.

Important distinction: **develop vs create**

create

focuses on bringing something into existence.

develop

focuses more on the gradual process of producing, refining, or expanding it.

> create an idea

> develop an idea

Not identical.

Important distinction: **develop vs build**

build

often means physically construct or assemble.

develop

is broader:

- * skills

- * products

- * land

- * relationships

- * arguments

- * diseases

So:

> build a house

> develop a housing project

Transitivity note

Develop can be both intransitive and transitive.

Intransitive

> “The city developed rapidly.”

「城市迅速發展。」

Transitive

> “The company developed a new product.”

「公司開發了一款新產品。」

This grammar difference is important.

Useful construction: **develop into — 發展成；變成**

Practice 22

> “The village developed into a large town.”

「那條村逐漸**發展成**一個大城鎮。」

Practice 23

> “The disagreement developed into a serious conflict.”

「這場分歧逐漸**演變成**嚴重衝突。」

develop into = 經過一段時間後逐漸變成另一種更完整 / 更嚴重的狀態

Useful construction: **develop from — 由……發展而來**

Practice 24

> “The idea developed from an earlier project.”

「這個想法是由較早的一個項目**發展而來**。」

Family-extension note

The practical modern family includes:

* **develop**
* **developed**
* **developing**
* **development**
* **developmental**
* **developer**

The word has several genuinely distinct branches: natural/social growth, deliberate product creation, emergence of illness/problems, land development, photographic processing, and expansion of ideas.

The key is not to split every object into a new meaning. For example, **develop confidence**, **develop skills**, and **develop a relationship** share the same underlying idea of gradually causing something to form or strengthen.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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develop — grow/change gradually	隨時間逐步發展、演變、成熟或變得更複雜
develop — create/product/system	透過設計、測試和改良逐步開發或研製某物
develop — skill/quality/relationship	使能力、特質、習慣或關係逐步形成並增強
develop — disease/problem/feature	某種疾病、症狀、問題或特徵開始出現
develop — situation/story	情況、事件或故事逐步展開或變化
develop — land	對土地進行建設、規劃或商業 / 住宅開發
develop — photography	對菲林 / 照片進行化學顯影或沖洗
develop — idea/argument	把想法、論點或主題進一步展開、深入闡述
development	發展；新進展；開發建設
developer	軟件 / 產品開發者；地產發展商

For your original sentence

> “...how human beings **developed**, cooperated, and built societies.”

The exact meaning is:

developed = 人類隨時間逐步演變、成長，並形成更複雜的能力與社會形式

So:

> **how human beings developed**

= **人類如何逐步發展 / 演變**

For your database, I would count **6 genuinely useful core meanings** for **develop**:

1. **grow/change gradually**
2. **create or improve a product/system/method**
3. **cause a skill, quality, relationship, etc. to form**
4. **begin to have a disease/problem/feature**
5. **develop land/property**
6. **process photographic film**

I would merge **develop a situation/story** into #1, merge **develop an argument/theme** into #2/#3 depending on your database structure, and keep **development / developmental / developer** as family extensions.